



We Wear the Mask

Paul Laurence Dunbar

We wear the mask that grins and lies,
It hides our cheeks and shades our eyes,—
This debt we pay to human guile;
With torn and bleeding hearts we smile,
5 And mouth with myriad subtleties.

sb. falskhed

adj. utallig

sb. listighed

Why should the world be over-wise,
In counting all our tears and sighs?
Nay, let them only see us, while
10 We wear the mask.

We smile, but, O great Christ, our cries
To thee from tortured souls arise.
We sing, but oh the clay is vile
15 Beneath our feet, and long the mile;
But let the world dream otherwise,
We wear the mask¹

adj. mod-
bydelig

¹Source: Paul Laurence. Dunbar, “We Wear the Mask.” from The Complete Poems of Paul Laurence Dunbar. Found on: <https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/44203/we-wear-the-mask>

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In pairs

1. Take turns reading the poem aloud to each other.
2. “Translate” the poem into prose.
3. Discuss who the “we” of the poem is, and what the mask is representing.
4. Identify the rhythm and rhyme scheme of the poem.
5. Choose two lines and comment on the language of the lines.
6. Discuss what the message or theme is in this poem.
7. Explain what about the language or the form of the poem you think indicates such a message/theme.
8. Discuss how identity is represented in the poem.